

My Quarto Document

Intro

My dissertation addresses two central questions for social epistemologists: the value of moral testimony and how to appropriately respond to morally laden situations in fiction. According to some, reliance on moral testimony is untenable. Epistemologists Alison [hill09; hill13; hill16] and Sarah [mcgr09; mcgr11] have expressed worries that moral testimony, while potentially valuable, should not be acted on. Moral actions that are based on moral testimony would have no moral worth. However, some of the more plausible explanations share an important feature with the second central question. We often expect active agency in the context of moral behavior. It is not enough that we act rightly, but our actions ought to reflect our understanding regarding the correct action. Moral reflection, unlike non-moral reflection, however, requires a richer form of understanding involving both cognitive and non-cognitive faculties. The right emotion ought to accompany our moral action. Like (1), (2) also concerns emotions. We have emotions toward fictions, however, these do not always mirror those we have in the real world. In some situations, an emotional response to fiction is apt though inapt outside of such contexts, e.g., slap-stick comedy. The right emotion need not accompany the audience of art. Jonathan Gilm21 argues that our emotions towards a given fiction is often justified just in case the emotion was the one intended by the author. The second problem then concerns the aptness of an expressed emotion. In chapter 2, I examine the relationship between fiction and the more robust form of moral understanding important for attributions of moral worth. I contrast standard epistemological cases with moral epistemological ones. Chapter 3 explores philosophical accounts of narrative. Following notable optimists in the literature on moral testimony, such as Eleanor Stump and Martha Nussbaum, I argue that narrative is a potential avenue for achieving affective moral understanding. I define affective moral understanding as feeling the right way at the right time in response to the right object. The philosophy of psychology literature often makes reference to the importance of identity for personal agency. It also addresses these concerns in moral epistemology regarding the importance of moral narratives for the construction of this identity. In chapter 4, I look at psychological accounts of narrative. I focus on a class of such accounts that draw a connection between narrative understanding and human flourishing. Following the psychology literature, I argue that human beings are social creatures, and as such, a prime component in human

flourishing are our relationships with others. Therefore, narratives which contribute to our understanding of the importance of these relationships in our lives can be tools we use to ensure the well-being of those we love. Finally, in chapter 5, I consider whether literary narratives central to human flourishing are necessarily classical works of literature. The question about apt emotional expression and art is often articulated as a form of moral enhancement. Art is said to have the ability to make us better persons. For instance, Elizabeth Glaskill’s “Mary Barton” is often credited with motivating the expanded public health care and other social goods that the United Kingdom provides. However, rarely is popular music discussed. Yet, it is likely that a greater proportion of a given population consume popular music rather than classical literature. I argue this raises a problem: if only classical works are central to human flourishing, then only classical works can potentially undermine human flourishing. So I expand my investigation to consider a class of non-classical works, namely popular narratives. Analyzing these narratives, I develop a model of non-classical literary works that satisfy both philosophical and psychological accounts of the close connection between narrative and human flourishing.

The Ethics of Care and Caring Audiences

In her 1982 book *In a Different Voice*, Carol Gilligan coins the term *Ethic of Care*. Gilligan argues women treat moral issues in terms of emotional responses. When a care-giver wants to teach the harms of bullying, they will often encourage a child to imagine being bullied. Moral philosophers since, recognize the importance of empathy in both public and private life. Highlighting the centrality of emotional expression in moral matters, we revitalize the works of seventeenth century sentimentalists, Hume, Hutcheson, Smith, etc. The resurgence focuses our attention to classical moral views grounded in empathy. In book VIII of the *Nicomachean Ethics*, Aristotle defines his ideal social constitution. He first ranks three types of friendships, the best of which he calls *friends of virtue*. Importantly, an individual of virtue appreciates the friendship and wishes the best for the friend, a desire rooted in empathy. He treats the best kinds of governments similarly to the best kinds of friendships.

Friendship and justice seem, as we have said at the outset of our discussion, to be concerned with the same objects and exhibited between the same persons. For in every community there is thought to be some form of justice, and friendship too; at least men address as friends their fellow-voyagers and fellow-soldiers, and so too those associated with them in any other kind of community.

Friendships, between individuals of virtue and civil polity correlate with empathy. The psychological phenomenon of empathy, at the foundation of the best types of friendships, is also at the heart of the best kinds of civil polities. Therefore, resting on an ethics of care account; I argue recognizing moral frameworks in fictional narratives enables us to acknowledge the importance of the expressions of care and empathy in human relationships.¹ Moral narratives

¹@slot07; @slot13; @gelf19

grounded in philosophical concepts of identity rely on constructions of empathy. The familiar story of Jesus weeping at the death of Lazarus becomes a story of Jesus weeping with Mary. Through empathy, our imagined relationships to depicted characters in fiction constrain our emotional expressions in a given context. We weep with others when their pain will shortly give way to rejoicing. An ethic of care provides us with an ability to understand the importance of narrative where other philosophical accounts fail. Now according to moral sentimentalism, the moral worth of an action depends on the sentiment it is grounded in, actions done without the right kind of corresponding affect are devoid of moral worth. Some call expressions of empathy *moral understanding*. Moral understanding is an affect which underlies our moral judgments motivating, accompanying, grounding our actions. It can also justify or explain our actions, etc. Accordingly, moral narrative is a form of moral testimony which relies on more than just our cognitive faculties, knowing right from wrong, but also our non-cognitive faculties as well, being motivated by the right affects.

Tragedy, Narrative and Behavior

However, the above view would seem to conflict with our standard responses to fiction, a phenomenon known as the emotional paradox of fiction. We have many varied responses to events in the real world that are constrained by certain facts about the real world. We are likely to have a great emotional response to the death of a loved one rather than the death of a stranger. We will appreciate a cheap trinket from a close sibling more than a cheap trinket from a stranger. We will worry more for a close son or daughter traveling in an unfamiliar foreign country than we will the son or daughter of a neighbor. Fictions often constrain our emotional responses in ways dis-analogous to the real world. It may take years in the real world to do what fiction can do in several chapters. We cry when Jess discovers Leslie's death in Katherine Patterson's *Bridge to Terabithia*. James Hurst's *The Scarlet Ibis* teaches us that we can develop empathy for a character even more quickly than suggested in novels when Doodle is left to die in a moment of adolescent insensitivity. What this means is that while I might experience sentimental approval, joy, glee, optimism in one context in fictional worlds, I do not necessarily need to have similar experiences in similar contexts in the real world to feel similar emotions.

This leads Jonathan @gilm20 to criticize the view that the emotions we have towards fiction are of the same kind that we have towards events in the real world. It would seem then that there are problems for the view that fictions are necessarily sources of the richer form of moral knowledge. This makes the use of tragedy to confer such important concepts related to valuable human relationships interesting. Tragedies are most immediately notable for the conflict in desires they give rise to, as expressed by a given moral conflict. The audience also experiences a similar moral conflict in their desire to consume the tragedy rather than turn away from it. Otherwise known as the paradox of tragedy, tragedies contain a feature wherein while we desire that some event take place, at the same time, we would not normally desire that such an

event take place, or we desire that the event doesn't take place. In tragedy then, we pursue experiences which conflict with our normal dispositions to avoid pain and distress.

Our interest in the tragedy suggests there may be a value that supersedes other values associated with the avoidance of pain and distress. Tragedy draws us in even though it is a source of emotions that we do not want to feel. Some values of tragedy include; opportunities to clarify our emotions, intrinsically valuable enlightenment about the nature of suffering; a safe experience of suffering; and an opportunity to clarify our own human vulnerability. Among these values, @gilm20 posits certain kinds of pleasure that may mitigate the pain that tragedy causes, e.g. some affective stimulation, positive or negative in valence, that we desire. It is not clear why the value inherent in tragedies needs to be rooted in pleasure however. Perhaps the value is rooted in something else, such as moral understanding. We can split the possible values into two categories.

Remark. Category One, Non-moral: Pleasure (affective stimulation), Opportunities to clarify our emotions

Category Two, Moral: Intrinsically valuable enlightenment about the nature of suffering, a safe experience of suffering, an opportunity to clarify our own human vulnerability in light of suffering

There is much that can be said about suffering, for instance that the existence of suffering can be explained by benefits that mitigate the suffering. For instance, there is a kind of suffering that we experience when reading the story of Job, or the suffering that he experienced. Through a narrative account of his suffering, we learn something about him. That he was devout and faithful for instance. More importantly, it would be one thing to hear that Job was devout and faithful, but a narrative about him remaining devout and faithful throughout his suffering, gives us a greater appreciation for the depth of his faithfulness. One way to understand the relationship between tragedy and narrative then, is by understanding how narrative can produce the benefits of, for instance, suffering, and it can do this without the suffering itself.

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Narrative and Narrative Identities

Gilmore considers a non-cognitivist evaluative account of the emotions wherein there is some way in which our moral judgments are grounded in approbation or praise. Initially the concern is whether our cognitive moral judgments inform our perceptive responses regarding what emotion we experience, or whether the emotion we experience grounds the corresponding judgment. It is standard for cognitivists to enforce the former while non-cognitivists endorse the latter. According to Gilmore however, neither account matters for his view because the emotion that we experience in response to a given fiction is not of the same kind as those we experience in real life [gil20, 59]. Although I may feel fear when walking down a dark alley, I would not feel a similar emotion when following a character down a dark alley. This is because in the context of fiction, I adopt the phenomenal states of that character, experiencing the world in the same way that he does. As such, the connection between the more deliberate operations of our cognition, such as judgment, and the reactive ones, is not clear. Because of this, it may be hard to determine how our reactions are grounded, in what part of our cognition they originate. In the following, I argue that identity is perhaps a better factor for determining our emotional disposition in the context of fiction.

Work on sentiment analysis suggests that moral content in messaging plays an instrumental role in cultivating various dynamics supervening on, or emerging from emotional states, such as our sense of identity (W. J. Brady et al. 2017; W. J. Brady and Crockett 2018; W. J. Brady, Gantman, and Bavel 2019; William J. Brady, Crockett, and Van Bavel 2020, 984). By understanding what gives rise to emotion then, we can better understand these dynamics and their associations with human behavior, for example group identity, and how it may inform what choices of action we decide on (Hopp et al. 2021; gram09?). According to one view of group identity, social identity theory, when group identities become highly relevant, for instance on social media platforms, emotions are motivated in terms of group rather than individual goals (William J. Brady, Crockett, and Van Bavel 2020, 987; tajf04?).

Grounded in earlier research at the intersections of language, emotions in behavioral and cognitive psychology, psycholinguistics, and the behavioral sciences [moha21, 2], work in moral psychology has often highlighted the importance of understanding emotion to understand our moral intuitions through the emotions instantiated. This project is important for understanding a wide range of issues ranging from online radicalization to vaccine hesitancy. By extracting and analyzing emotional content in messages; narratives; and other forms of public discourse, we can better understand how the psychological influences of moral judgments affect broader global populations through the emotions anticipated in a given text [moha21]. Researchers are studying sentiment analysis, attempt to discover what emotional states are most likely being experienced by the audience of a given narrative. Looking at the word count of words associated with positive or negative sentiment / valence, and the semantic placement of words associated with a given sentiment [rink19] is one way to analyze the moral content in messaging found in social and traditional media, contemporary archives, or Victorian literature.² Such research

²@See @alfa22; @osgo57 for a look at some of the historical developments in textual analysis.

helps us to better understand human behavior and our decision-making processes by helping us to understand one’s attitudes towards a given topic. Assuming a given attitude may inform us of particular behavioral dispositions. However, these claims are contentious. A better method involves understanding those emotions one is likely to have based on what communities they belong to.

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Similarly, there is also evidence that suggests that public moral content influences the individual cognitive processes of individuals when phrases loaded with moral implications are processed more quickly by our cognitive processes⁴ Some individuals argue that this occurs in news reporting, motivating research into what emotional states are most likely to be experienced by which audiences [@haid22]. Assuming that we align politically with a given party, we may experience more anger when viewing one news report as opposed to another. Another branch analyzes the importance of personal and public narratives and the roles that these play in identity development [@mcle15; @mcle15b?; @brun90].

One important aspect for factors that motivate our emotions is found in the psychology of personality literature. Here, personal narratives are a subjective understanding of how one came to be the person they currently are [@mcad01]. We can infer a person’s expected emotion by referencing various contextual factors such as one’s social group and class [@tajf04]. Much of the research has defined two kinds of narratives, master and personal. A master narrative is a script that is held publicly by a group of individuals. These are defined as culturally shared stories that guide one’s beliefs, behaviors, and values [@bamb04]. Accordingly, an individual often shares the values of the community she belongs to. These values are defined through her scripts which are often indisputable by rational members of a given community, for instance the moon landing in 1969 and one’s assertion of them defines membership in that community. @fivu04 have called these immersive socialization processes [also see @book22] and argue that they are socialization processes, a system of human developments that includes language, memory, and identity. As a contrast, personal narratives are autobiographies which we use to explain how we became the person that we are. While there is significant research on both master and personal narratives, what is less well known are the cultural contexts of personal narratives. Because of the large interplay between social scripting, and what one believes about herself, our personal narratives often emerge in relation to master ones. However, it is not well known how master narratives factor into one’s own autobiography. Some plausibilities

³@brad17; @brad18; @brad19; @brad20, 984

⁴@hopp21; @brad20; @gant14; @gant16

possibilities can include a common example narrative about a shared recognition of the value of knowledge and understanding held by the members of a particular Russian Jewish community for instance. Academic success by one of the members of the community may be explained by reference to this shared communal value. Intelligence and cognitive ability then is not a surprise outcome but expected. Even more importantly here, while master and personal narratives often converge, they can also conflict. Not only can they do this in matters of traditional cognitive ability, but also moral cognitive ability.

One way to understand the relationship between moral understanding and master narrative is provided by @alfa13 in his book *Character as Moral Fiction*. Alfano argues that moral technology is a form of character attribution wherein we assert various positive moral traits of a given individual regardless of the truth value for such a claim. Importantly however, the given trait attribution is not demonstrably false and therefore remains a possibility. Because of this possibility, the assertion is a placebo which motivates the object to begin believing certain facts about themselves. Referring to the fact that there is a positive correlation between the story about whether one possesses a moral virtue, and associated behaviors stemming from that possibility, we might think that positive moral trait attribution is a kind of moral testimony wherein one comes to believe certain moral facts about themselves and behaves accordingly. However, in relation to a worry by epistemologists regarding moral testimony as a source for moral knowledge [@hill09; @hopk07; @nick01; @enoc14], that we do not have any reason to trust it [e.g., see @hopk07; @hill09], there may be various reasons why one would think that narrative as a form of testimony is sufficient for moral knowledge whereas traditional testimony is not. To understand why this might be the case, we should contrast narratives with what we know about empathy and group identity. Our reliance on moral narrative as a guide for our behavior can bestow moral justification on our behavior in that we might experience an emotional event that motivates a given moral action.

Moral Testimony

Alternative narratives are important in contrast to personal and master narratives as they enable an individual to conceptualize their personal narrative in contrast to a culturally shared negative one. An individual falling under a socially attributed stereotype may believe that certain unproductive behavior for them is expected and therefore excused. However, another who rejects the broader social organization by accepting alternative narratives instead of the master one, may not excuse themselves for sub-par behavior. Additionally, alternative narratives can change public perceptions mitigating harmful stereotypes. For instance, @harr11 argues that we have a similarity bias which is the root cause of emotions of empathy [Also see @haro03]. Harris argues that Emily Gaskell's novel *Mary Barton*, evoked the similarity bias of Britain's upper-class by describing the socially poor in London as people with similar motives and concerns as the ruling and wealthy class, creating empathic relations between the upper and lower classes of London. This empathy was central to Britain's expanded social safety net.

Corresponding with various group dynamics in regard to the motivations for the expression of our emotions, the other concern then, is a broader, and perhaps more controversial one. On the relationship between art and ethics [Gilm20; Stol92; Gaut03; Palmer, Begley, and Coe13], a primary point has to do with our emotions in relation to fictional contexts, namely when is an emotional experience an apt response to a fictional representation. I argue that the intractability of these two concerns, which have been up until now considered separately, is due to the fact that we do not often consider their relation to one another. Drawing on claims regarding the connection between narratives and emotional states [especially by Nuss85], we might ask ‘what might a morally expressive emotion look like?’ Martha Nussbaum, Eleonore Stump and Linda Zagzebski have argued that morally significant intimate relationships depicted in narratives between two or more individuals necessarily involve morally significant emotional states. The ways in which these emotional states have moral significance vary. For instance, Zazb17 articulates emotions as having objects which in the state characterized by that emotion, the object of the emotion appears to us as having the property characterized by that emotion. Objects which appear admirable to us, motivate us to emulate those objects [Also see Algo09].

This has implications if, as some have claimed, narratives are important for facilitating empathic relationships among individuals by expressing the emotional states of the characters in morally appropriate ways. We might think, for instance, that emotions can constitute a type of perception where we recognize the moral significance of a situation by our affective perception of it (M. Nuss85, 521). Henry James (1985)’s *The Golden Bowl* represents such an ethical representation when Maggie Verver, for the first time, embraces her husband with an emotion commonly reserved for lovers. The artistic engagement is noted by the motivations and intentions of the artist. As such, we may think that the values associated with e.g., tragedy, are those defined by the author, but not intrinsic, or emerging from the work apart from the author’s intentions. Can we find natural moral content in narratives wherein the author hadn’t meant to include? Can a narrative cultivate a harmful stereotype apart from the author’s intentions or does the lack of intention negate the harm?

In aesthetics literature, there is debate about whether a work depicting a particular event can motivate an emotional state contrary to a similar event in the real world. We can call continuityists those who claim that narratives are important for facilitating empathic relationships among individuals by expressing the emotional states of the characters in morally appropriate ways. There are two relevant components of such an argument, however. One says that the relations depicted by narratives are normatively descriptive of moral [Nuss85], or admirable [Zagz17] relations among individuals. However, others may suggest [Gilm20; Mora94], that such depictions may rest heavily on sufficient artistic engagement, or attunement by the artist, and a particular sensitivity to the relevant moral issues, noted particularly by the motivations and intentions of the artist. They may argue, any less literary engagement with these contexts will not sufficiently express the complex moral frameworks Nussbaum, Stump and Zagzebski find in literature (*The View*).

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relationships among individuals by expressing the emotional states of the characters in morally appropriate ways. We might think, for instance, that emotions can constitute a type of perception where we recognize the moral significance of a situation by our affective perception of it [Nuss85, 521]. James's *The Golden Bowl* represents such an ethical representation when Maggie Verver, for the first time, embraces her husband with an emotion commonly reserved for lovers. The artistic engagement is noted by the motivations and intentions of the artist. As such, we may think that the values associated with e.g., tragedy, are those defined by the author, but not intrinsic, or emerging from the work apart from the author's intentions. Can we find natural moral content in narratives wherein the author hadn't meant to include? Can a narrative cultivate a harmful stereotype apart from the author's intentions or does the lack of intention negate the harm?

A debate in aesthetic literature might undermine optimism about moral testimony through narrative. The discontinuity thesis is the view that our emotions in fictional worlds do not need to be continuous to those in the real world. Some have claimed that narratives are important for facilitating empathic relationships among individuals by expressing the emotional states of the characters in morally appropriate ways [Nuss83; Arpa04]. The way we respond to fiction can drastically depart from our responses to their real-life counterparts. Our affectations can also radically differ and a part of the explanation for this is that objects in fictions are presented to us in ways that differ from the presentations of their real-life counterparts. The aims of the artists determine these framing effects. There is a worry here however and one goal of this dissertation is to motivate a different way of thinking about narratives which highlights their extra-aesthetic properties regardless of the artistic intent behind the work. I will propose a sentimentalist account of moral testimony based on narrative. In doing so, I will highlight the necessary relationship between moral knowledge and narrative. In the end, I will have a better account of narrative, one which provides an explanation of what they are and what they do. On this viewIn my account, narratives are forms of moral communication. They can undermine or build up one's moral knowledge. They are moral in that they represent human emotions in the contexts of human and human or human and other sentience relationships. Not only do narratives cognitively show us what important relationships are like, but more importantly they show us what such relationships feel like. Such effects are important for moral worth in action. Because of their ability to elicit affect, narratives are important sources of moral knowledge. A central question to be resolved in the first section is the asymmetry problem between moral and non-moral testimony. Optimists argue that though it may not always be optimal, moral testimony is an acceptable source of moral knowledge. By contrast however, pessimists argue that though it can confer knowledge, moral testimony does not confer moral worth which can only be obtained through moral understanding. As such, moral testimony is useless.

Alongside narratives in literature, there are other disciplines which tell us about individuals in communities outside our own. We may read the reports of a past explorer and obtain an awareness of various propositions about the cultures encountered by them. However, we are likely to question the authenticity of a report if we have reason to suspect the author has a

personal bias coloring the analysis. Importantly here is the question of whether it is possible to learn about others through narrative.

It is curious that while we may worry about a historian's bias corrupting a particular character analysis of a historical figure, concern is not similarly expressed regarding a created narrative.

It should be clear that, for my purposes in this book, it does not matter whether or not the narratives I examine are revealed. A defense is a story that accounts for the existence of God and the existence of the suffering in our world and that is not demonstrably false; a defense does not need to claim that the reasons it ascribes to God for allowing suffering are God's actual reasons, only that they might be God's reasons, for all we know. Stump (2010)

We may have reason to be concerned with bias regarding Job's account. We hear about the Christian virtues of a particular e.g., politician, through narrative, and only find out later that this individual was hiding a particularly horrific sin. A question that arises then is 'what are the benefits incurred by our suffering in tragedies?'

Moral Perception of Others

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Perhaps it is because the created narrative requires us to use our own imaginations, rather than the imaginations of the narrative's author, in order to understand what a historical figure might have been like, how they might have perceived the world, what their phenomenological responses to events in the world may have felt like. Accordingly, we might think that although many facts in the narrative that we were led to believe were false, especially those corresponding with the virtue of the individual, these in themselves are not important. There are other facts, maybe, which are more enduring, such as a story of an individual, who if they did possess certain character traits, would have been a very admirable person. As such, the important truths conveyed through the narrative are hypothetical. If a given individual were to possess some particular virtue, then they would perhaps view the world a given way.

Although we may read in the new testament bible that Jesus is God, we may think that the new testament also wants to show us that Jesus is human. Therefore, upon seeing Mary weep at the death of her brother Lazarus, Jesus himself weeps, even though Jesus knows that in just a moment, Lazarus will be raised to life [John 11:35]. He is affected emotionally rather than cognitively. Rather than just relying on the testimony of the text's author then, we are contributing as much to the analysis of Jesus, through our imaginations, as the author.

Attempting to understand narratives as they are, we can come to understand the character, what he or she is like, that Job is faithful, God is human, a given saint is virtuous. But why should we trust these accounts?

Much of what is involved in the representation relies on our own imaginative faculties, we can imagine Job sitting on the floor of his tent in extreme agony, and then from the foggy recesses of his mind, hearing God's voice. We may imagine that it is gentle and nourishing, or that it is harsh in its rebuke of Job's accusations against God. As such, it does appear that there are some qualifications for understanding what an agent is like through narratives. The narrative accounts for some proposition related to that agent, that in some sense they exist and that certain propositions about them are true. However, the particular features of the narrative which act as reasons are reasons why a proposition is not demonstrably false rather than true, and once again, what is not demonstrably false are the positive character attributions directed at a given individual. Once again, we should reject this response assuming that we are attempting to attribute positive characteristics to demonstrably vicious individuals, such as the wayward politician. However there are other ways in which we can attribute the important traits of virtue regardless of the virtue or vice of the represented person. If the character is an obvious fictional character, then it does not seem that we can commit any harm in the ways we would if we were to attribute similar traits to those who have, unbeknownst to us, committed incredible evil. Another method, however, is by attributing these to individuals whose lives existed so deep into history that it is questionable whether they ever truly existed. If we imagine that Job hears God's voice, this is because it has not been communicated in the context of the narrative, that Job does not hear God's voice. Job's life, by now, verges on the mythical and if this is plausible, then I suppose it's perfectly fine, for mythical humans hear God's voice all the time.

Caring Audiences

Resting on an ethics of care account then [Gelfand; Smith; Gelfand]; I argue that recognizing moral frameworks in fictional narratives, begins with the audience empathizing, or desiring to empathize with a given character. It begins in the concept of identity. Such an ethic is grounded on sentiments of care wherein our imagined relationships to depicted characters in fiction constrain our emotional expressions in a given context. Michael Gelfand provides a systematic account of why more traditional accounts are insufficient for motivating our intuitions about why some actions fail to possess moral worth. Moral understanding here, is thought of as moral motivation where we have various affects which underlie our moral judgments. Such affects

motivate our actions, accompany our actions etc. According to this sentimentalist view, actions done without these corresponding affects are devoid of moral worth. As such, what we have then are pessimists about moral testimony, mt, optimists about mt, and the sentimentalists who can either be thought of as optimists or pessimists with respect to moral testimony. Most sentimentalists however are primarily sentimental pessimists. Narrative then, is a form of moral testimony which relies on more than just our cognitive faculties, but also our non-cognitive faculties as well.

What this means is that while I might experience sentimental approval, joy, glee, optimism in one context in fictional worlds, I do not necessarily need to have similar experiences in similar contexts in the real world. Here, what makes an emotional expression apt in regards to fiction, is whether or not the audience intends to engage with that fiction, and doing so aptly, means experiencing those emotional expressions intended by the creator of the work.

If an audience member is unhappy with the emotion prescribed by an artist, they can decline engaging with that work of art. Even more damning for my argument, is the fact that it is likely that sentimental optimists may accept this conclusion. According to them, only some literature can be thought of as a source for moral knowledge. This is unacceptable. What it leaves is a conclusion that while some literature is a source for moral knowledge, it is not necessarily the case that any literature undermines one's moral knowledge. For instance, works for the intents of pleasure, are not intended for moral knowledge and therefore will be unable to undermine moral knowledge. If the work is particularly morally problematic, it is not the work, but the audience that is culpable. To fix this, I suggest that sentimental optimists classify any work which represents human emotion in the context of human other relationships as narrative. As such, continuists and discontinuists have differing conceptions of narrative. As a way to make the two commensurable, I suggest we define narrative in such a way that each discussant can accept. On a care account, a systematic way to recognize moral frameworks in narratives can be modeled on a sentimentalist ethics, specifically a care ethic, enabling us to recognize moral testimony as a source of moral knowledge in a way other ethical theories do not. Such accounts of moral testimony then would necessarily include narratives and therefore on an ethics of care account of moral testimony, narrative is an important source of moral knowledge not recognized in the literature as a kind of moral testimony. In the first section, I argue that the asymmetry of moral testimony is really a question about whether or not testimony confers morally worthy affective states. In the second section, I further expand on this idea using literary examples showing the importance of affective states in moral reasoning and how without appropriate affect, there is something missing in moral action. Because I've shown the importance of affective states in moral reasoning, and how narratives are supremely important for showing this relation, I continue the following section by looking at some more relationships between narratives and morally worthy actions. I start by looking at a specific conversation between those who think that our emotions towards fictions are governed by the same criteria as our emotions towards situations in the real world, and those who disagree. Without declaring a side, I continue the next section by further highlighting some reasons in favor of each view. In the final section, I develop a model which will highlight important aspects of moral knowledge in narrative accounts.